CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

CATERER IN THE AI ERA

The only owner-flavoured title in food that a beginner can legally open in year one — the gate is a permit stack and a rented commissary, not a loan and a lease.

★ TL;DR — YES. There is no BLS occupation called Caterer, so the pay is labelled as its anchor: Food Service Managers, median $69,390 (BLS, May 2025), +6%, ~38,800 openings a year. A beginner enters two ways, both open in 2027: hired into catering work immediately at the cook layer (cooks median $36,640; catering attendants ~$15–19/hr in aggregator postings), or opening a permitted catering business the same year. Owner income itself has no verified median — first-year reality is cook-layer pay plus a growing book of events, not $69K. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

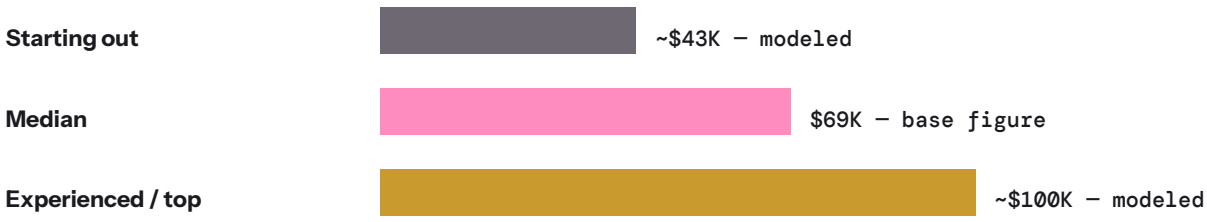
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$69K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Nobody gatekeeps the title: no agency wall, no experience requirement imposed by any anchor — the employed door and the business door are both open in year one.
- The real gate is legal, flat and passable: you must operate from an approved commissary or commercial kitchen and hold your own food-facility/catering permit, with a Certified Food Manager where required — licences of days-to-weeks, not years.
- AI does none of this work: nothing cooks, transports, sets up or serves event food by machine. The entry taxes are commissary rent and paid leads (Thumbtack sells caterer contacts pay-per-lead, roughly $15–80 in third-party compilations).

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Caterer is a ~$69K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A CATERER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Cook for events: weddings, offices, parties — food that travels and holds
- ✓ Price events end-to-end: food cost, labour, rentals, kitchen time
- ✓ Run the event on site: transport, setup, service, breakdown
- ✓ Win the next booking from this one — referrals are the whole marketing department

Think: a restaurant that exists for exactly one night, in someone else's venue, with no second chance to get dinner right.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Nothing at the core: event food is physical, on-site and per-event custom. Platforms intermediate the client search (pay-per-lead marketplaces) — a toll on acquisition, not automation of the work.	Menu judgment for a crowd you've never fed, timing a hot hold across town, rescuing a timeline when the venue runs late — live, unscripted, in person.

⚠ **Do not start unpermitted and do not lean on cottage-food law: state cottage-food regimes cover only non-potentially-hazardous, direct-to-consumer packaged foods and exclude meat, dairy and anything needing temperature control — prepared event meals require the caterer permit (e.g., Florida licenses caterers through DBPR with a Certified Food Manager required; King County, WA requires catering from an approved commissary kitchen plus your own operating permit). And price the tolls honestly: commissary rent is due before your first event, and lead platforms charge per contact whether or not you book.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Open door, twice: employed catering work now, your own permitted business this year ✓ The anchors are growing: Food Service Managers +6%, Cooks +7% (BLS) ✓ Every event is a portfolio piece and a referral engine at once	✗ First-year money is cook-layer money (~$31–37K employed) plus early, lumpy event income ✗ Weekend-heavy, deadline-brutal work with zero redo on the night ✗ Kitchen rent and paid leads tax you before revenue starts

Good fit? You cook well under pressure, price honestly, and want a business whose capital test is a permit, not a mortgage.
Bad fit? You want a salary at the $69K anchor in year one, or weeknights-and-weekends-off predictability.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — HIRED INTO CATERING	DOOR B — YOUR OWN PERMITTED BUSINESS
The employed route: catering companies, hotels and banquet facilities hire cooks, attendants and servers with no formal education requirement. You are paid at the cook layer (BLS cooks median $36,640; restaurant cooks $17.98/hr) while learning event math from inside — production volumes, holding, transport, staffing ratios. A full season inside a good operation is the cheapest catering school that exists. First move: get hired for one full event season and work every role at least twice.	The ownership route, legally open in year one: register the business, secure a commissary agreement (the permit requires it), pass plan review and inspection for your food-facility/catering permit, hold the food-manager certification — then sell small events and grow the book. No vehicle purchase, no lease, no lender. First move: get your county health department's caterer checklist and price the whole stack before you print a menu.

Smart move: Price events like an operator, not a cook: food cost, paid labour (including yours), kitchen rent, rentals, transport and lead cost — then profit. The caterers who survive are not the best cooks; they are the ones whose quotes never surprise them.
Where you land after: Lead cook or event captain inside a strong operation — or your own permitted catering business with a book of repeat clients, at the $69K anchor's altitude instead of a cook's ceiling.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	GET INSIDE	PASS THE	LEARN THE	SELL THE	CHOOSE YOUR

STEP 1 — Read the real numbers

FREE · TODAY

- Read the anchors: Food Service Managers $69,390 (the business anchor), Cooks $36,640 (your employed entry layer)
- Accept the split in writing: the anchor is the destination; year one pays cook-layer money

STEP 2 — Get inside a catering operation

WEEKS 1-4

- Hire on with a catering company, hotel or banquet facility for a full season
- Work production, transport, setup and service — every role at least twice

STEP 3 — Pass the permit stack (Door B groundwork)

MONTHS 1-3

- Get your health department's caterer checklist: commissary agreement, food-facility permit, plan review, inspection
- Complete the Certified Food Manager / food-safety certification your jurisdiction requires

STEP 4 — Learn the event math

MONTHS 2-6

- Rebuild three real event quotes from your employer's book: food %, labour, rentals, kitchen, leads
- Set your own price sheet only after your numbers match theirs

STEP 5 — Sell the first small events

MONTHS 4-9

- Start with formats you can execute solo from the commissary: office lunches, small celebrations, brunch service
- Photograph everything and collect named references — the book compounds

STEP 6 — Choose your altitude

YEAR 1

- Stay employed and climb (lead cook, event captain) if the book is thin
- Shift weight to your own business as repeat clients cover the commissary rent — that crossover is the real promotion

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: pull your county's caterer permit checklist and read the BLS Food Service Managers anchor numbers.
- □ Days 1–30: hired into a catering operation (or applications out); permit stack priced.
- □ Days 31–60: working events in every role; food-manager certification done.
- □ Days 61–90: first event quotes rebuilt and understood; your own price sheet drafted.
- □ Day 90: you're inside the business legally and literately — with a book starting to grow.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test

· Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ PERMIT FIRST. THEN FEAST. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.